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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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When I was about fourteen years old it was time for me to be married; ¹⁰⁸ I had grown up with our six 'fathers', the sons of Ibrahim Dara and his younger brother Maidamishi, and when the time came they arranged my marriage within the family, a marriage of kinsfolk. I was married to Duma the son of Sidi; Sidi was the son of my grandfather Mai Yana, Mai Yana and Ibrahim Dara being the sons of two brothers. I called Sidi 'father' and his son Duma was my elder brother; I called him 'Yaya'. Duma's father Sidi and my father put their heads together, the elder brother said to my father, 'We will marry them to one another', and his younger brother replied 'Very well'. They were always arranging marriages between kinsfolk in our family, everyone married his kinswoman and took her to his compound. My mother was dead at that time, and my father's sister Rabi was like my mother, ¹⁰⁹ but she had been kidnapped. My father sent for me and I went to him and curtsied. 'Your kinsman desires you,' he said; 'I also desire him,' I replied.

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Dabo, the son of Sarkin Zarewa our town chief, loved me and I wanted him, but my family would not agree to our marrying, they did not like titles and title-holders; they were farmers, they liked their daughters to marry farmers. (¹¹⁰) We often married into the families of blacksmiths, too; blacksmiths are the farmers' friends, they make our tools. Blacksmiths and farmers like to join their children in marriage. (¹¹¹) But the chief of the town was a Fulani, and we are Kado—Habe, the people who have been here since long before the Fulani came; Habe are free, not like a *dimajo* or a *bacucane*, they are two names for the same thing—the son of a slave, a man born in captivity. We came from Bornu but we were like Habe, and my family did not like to marry

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into families who  103 held ruling titles, in spite of the fact that Bornu people and Fulani are joking relations—Barebare and Fulani. (¹¹²) That was why could not marry Sarkin Zarewa's son. There was also Malam Maigari who wished to marry me, I promised him I would come to him later.

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Hausa girls are usually married when thirteen or fourteen years old, rarely at fifteen. A girl's parents often try to arrange for her to marry one of her kinsmen, paternal or maternal, in the kind of marriage known as *auren zumunci*, as Baba's father did.

Rabi took the place of Baba's mother after her own mother's death, and Baba often referred to her as 'my mother' in the real as well as the classificatory sense.

Her father's people were primarily farmers, and in addition many of them were *mallams* (Koranic scholars).

Blacksmiths and farmers—preferred marriage between occupational groups.

A conflict of institutionalized relations was here involved; as **joking**-relations of the Fulani, it was proper for Baba's kin to give her to the Zarewa chiefs; but as *malams* and farmers there was an opposition of interest and occupational class between them and the town chief.

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